VIT Bhopal University

VITyarthi E-Learning Platform

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

Project Report

Name	Harshwardhan Singh Panwar
Reg. No.	25MIM10042
Branch	Integrated MTech AI – First Year
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Introduction

This project report is submitted as part of the CSE0001 Digital Literacy course, The assignment is structured around a scenario in which I Harshwardhan Singh Panwar, Reg. No. 25MIM10042, take on the role of a Student Digital Ambassador, someone responsible for helping fellow students navigate the digital world safely, professionally, and effectively.

The project is divided into five tasks, each corresponding to a module of the course. These tasks cover: creating a digital literacy infographic, building a professional online portfolio, exploring coding and collaboration platforms, practising professional email communication, and developing cybercrime awareness resources.

All tools used in this project are free and browser-based, requiring no prior coding knowledge. The completed work is organised in a GitHub repository, which itself forms part of the permanent digital portfolio. This report documents the process, tools used, observations, and personal reflections for each task.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

Tool Used, Design Description & Reflection

For Task 1, I created a one-page Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic using Canva, a free and beginner-friendly design tool. I chose Canva because it offers prebuilt templates that are visually appealing and easy to customise without any graphic design experience.

My infographic covers three key topics: (1) What Digital Literacy means , defined as the ability to use digital tools effectively, safely, and responsibly; (2) Safe Internet Practices, including tips like using strong passwords, recognising phishing links, and enabling two-factor authentication; and (3) Professional Online Presence , highlighting the importance of platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub for students entering the job market.

The design uses a clean blue-and-white colour scheme with icons, short bullet points, and a central title section. I kept the content minimal so that it is easy to read at a glance and suitable for sharing on WhatsApp groups or college notice boards.

One thing I found particularly challenging was deciding how much text to include. My first draft was too text-heavy and looked cluttered. I found it interesting to learn how visual hierarchy, using font size and colour to guide the reader's eye, makes a huge difference to readability. This task taught me that effective communication is not just about words, but about presentation and design thinking.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Platforms Set Up, Purpose & Future Plans

For Task 2, I created or updated accounts on three professional platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. Each platform serves a distinct and important purpose in a student's digital professional life.

GitHub is a version control and code hosting platform. I created a profile README repository, named after my username, that is automatically displayed on my GitHub profile. It includes my name, branch, year, and a brief statement about my learning goals. GitHub will be central to my academic journey every project, assignment, and personal coding experiment can be documented and showcased here.

LinkedIn is the world's largest professional networking platform. I filled in my Education section with my current degree Integrated MTech, institution VIT Bhopal University, and expected graduation year. LinkedIn will become increasingly important from my second year onwards when I begin seeking internships and research opportunities.

Kaggle is a platform for data science and machine learning. Even though I am only in my first year, creating an account early allows me to start exploring datasets and community notebooks at my own pace.

Over the next five years, I plan to use GitHub as a live portfolio of all my technical work, LinkedIn for professional networking and internship applications, and Kaggle for developing data science skills from my second year onwards.

Task 3 – Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Platforms Used, What Was Built & Academic Value

Task 3 had two parts: a coding practice activity and a collaboration tool activity.

For Part A, I created an account on HackerRank and completed the 'Python Basics' challenge a beginner-level problem. While this is a very simple problem, the process of reading the problem statement, understanding the input/output format, writing code in the browser editor, and submitting for automated testing gave me firsthand experience of how competitive coding platforms work. I also explored the Python Introduction domain, which has a structured skill track suitable for complete beginners.

For Part B, I created a 5-question Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz using Google Forms. The quiz includes: Three multiple choice questions, One Short Answer, One Checklist, about Digital Literacy Including

The Google Form is linked to a Google Sheet that automatically records all responses, making it easy to view class-wide awareness levels briefly.

These tools will help me academically by providing structured practice environments Hacker Rank, improving my collaboration and data collection skills Google Workspace, and preparing me for technical interviews which commonly use browser-based coding platforms.

Task 4 – Professional Email & Etiquette Guide

Communication Scenario & Key Learnings

Task 4 required me to draft two professional emails and create a social media etiquette checklist. This task made me realise how much unspoken structure and expectation exists in professional digital communication.

The first email was addressed to a professor, requesting a deadline extension for this very assignment. I found that writing this email was harder than expected keeping it concise while including all the necessary context who I am, what I need, and why without sounding demanding or over-apologetic required careful drafting. The second email was addressed to an internship coordinator, expressing interest in a summer internship. This required a different tone, confident but not arrogant, enthusiastic but professional.

In terms of a communication failure scenario: a common real-world example is students messaging professors on WhatsApp without a greeting, sending just 'Sir marks?' or 'Send notes' with no context, name, or subject. This comes across as disrespectful and unprofessional. The simple fix is to treat every digital message to a professional as you would a formal letter: introduce yourself, state your purpose clearly, and close with a proper sign-off.

The key to learning from this task is that professional communication is a learnable skill and developing it early even before internships begin sets a student apart significantly in the eyes of faculty and recruiters.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

Surprising Findings & Personal Habit Change

For Task 5, I researched UPI and Online Payment Fraud a cybercrime type that is particularly prevalent and rapidly growing in India. I wrote a 250-word case study based on a realistic scenario of a college student who fell victim to a UPI Collect Request while trying to sell a laptop online.

What surprised me most during my research was how technically simple these attacks are. The scammer does not need any hacking skills at all they rely entirely on the victim's confusion about how UPI works. The key deception is making the victim believe that entering their UPI PIN is required to receive money, when in reality it only ever authorises sending money. This is a purely psychological attack, not a technical one.

I was also surprised to learn how many such cases go unreported in India because victims feel embarrassed, or do not know that a dedicated helpline (1930) and portal (cybercrime.gov.in) exist for exactly these situations.

As a direct result of this research, the one habit I will personally change is: I will never approve a UPI notification whether a Collect Request or a payment link without reading the full details on screen first, regardless of how urgent or convincing the caller sounds. Urgency is the attacker's primary weapon, a few seconds of careful reading is the most effective defence.

Conclusion

This Digital Literacy project has been a comprehensive and practical introduction to the digital skills that every engineering student needs today. Across five tasks, I learned to create visual communication resources, establish a professional digital presence, use coding and collaboration platforms, communicate professionally via email, and understand the real-world threat landscape of cybercrime in India.

Beyond the individual tasks, the project taught me that digital literacy is not a single skill but a mindset one that combines technical awareness, professional judgement, and responsible behaviour online. The GitHub repository I have built through this assignment is not just a submission; it is the beginning of a living portfolio that I intend to grow throughout my four years at VIT Bhopal University.

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